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Troubling the Functional/Dysfunctional Family Binary Through the Articulation of Functional Family Estrangement

Jordan Allen  & Julia Moore 

Critical perspectives remain largely absent from the study of family communication. To interrogate the power of discourse to construct knowledges about how family is and should be, we drew on Judith Butler's poststructural theory of performativity to critically analyze the common experience of family estrangement. We argue that professional discourse performatively constructs the functional family binary by equating ongoing, open, and positive family communication with functional family identity, while constructing estrangement as unnatural, dysfunctional, and in need of intervention. We then illustrate how some individuals who self-identify as estranged from a family member "trouble" the functional/dysfunctional family binary by articulating their own families as functionally estranged.

Keywords: *Critical Qualitative Inquiry; Discourse; Estrangement; Family Communication; Performativity*

Embodying the professional discourse surrounding estrangement, in a 2013 interview with the *Today Show*, psychologist Dr. Joshua Coleman likened familial estrangement to a "silent epidemic." More than a commentary on the frequency of estrangement (Coleman, 2009; Ipsos MORI, 2014), this description represents the prevailing understanding of estrangement as a family malady that plagues society. Both scholars and professionals have contributed to a robust body of literature on the topic of family estrangement (e.g., Agllias, 2011a, 2011b; 2013, 2015, 2016; Carr, Holman, Abetz,

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Koenig Kellas, & Vagnoni, 2015; Robinson, Carroll, & Flowers, 2001; Sichel, 2004; Sucov, 2006). Most definitions of estrangement indicate that it results in a disruption of normal and appropriate family functioning, if not a complete discontinuation of a relationship altogether. For example, Friedlander and Walters (2010) contend that in its most basic presentation estrangement is the “impairment in the parent-child relationship” resulting from a range of causes, “from intimate partner violence, abuse or neglect, to less dramatic but still significant behaviors such as inadequate parenting or chronic parental insensitivity” (p. 109). Similarly, Agllias (2013) argues that physical distancing, lack of emotional intimacy, relational dissatisfaction, conflict/avoidance, and the perceived lack of a resolution are key indicators of family estrangement.

Through critical-qualitative analysis framed by Butler’s (1990, 1993) poststructural theory of performativity, our purpose was to analyze professional and participant discourses of estranged family identity. To do so, we situate the present study within the conversation about critical approaches to family communication.

RATIONALE: THE NEED FOR CRITICAL ORIENTATIONS IN FAMILY COMMUNICATION RESEARCH

Since the critical turn in rhetoric and organizational communication (McKerrow, 1989; Mumby, 1993), a number of scholars of interpersonal and family communication have called for the integration of critical perspectives into the study of relationships and families (Baxter, 1992; Baxter & Asbury, 2014; Baxter & Braithwaite, 2006; Braithwaite, Moore, & Abetz, 2014; Braithwaite, Schrod, & Carr, 2014; Lannamann, 1992; Soliz, 2015; Suter, 2016). Baxter and Asbury (2014) argued that only three critical theories are presently employed by scholars of family communication: feminist theories (Few-Demo, Lloyd, & Allen, 2014; Wood, 2006), relational dialectics theory (Baxter, 2011; Baxter & Norwood, 2015), and narrative performance theory (Langelier & Peterson, 2004, 2006). Indeed, these theories are considered critical because they attend “to how power functions in communicative life with the twin scholarly goals of emancipation and empowerment” (Baxter & Asbury, 2014, p. 190). However, the vast majority of family communication scholars continue to eschew critical perspectives (Baxter & Braithwaite, 2006).

We contend that part of the issue is that our tradition of family communication lacks empirical examples that illustrate *how* critical research might be done on topics of family communication. Therefore, we offer a data-based critical analysis about estrangement that might model a new critical direction in family communication research. Although empirical family communication publications often follow a deductive writing logic of introduction, literature review, method, and discussion (Tracy, 2012), we offer a modification to this structure in order to facilitate the juxtaposition and critique of professional and vernacular discourse. Instead of offering an extensive literature review on the topic of estrangement up front to justify the present study, we instead align with the critical-qualitative project of “deconstructive critique” (Saukko, 2003, p. 21), which

unearths taken-for-granted knowledges imbued in dominant, binaristic discourse. In this case the dominant discourse we critique is constructed in the scholarly and professional literature itself. Thus, we adopt Tracy's (2012) argument to purposefully resist a deductive writing logic because "the deductive style limits and focuses analysis to existing knowledge" (p. 119). We instead narrativize our methodological approach first to foreground an inductive rather than deductive approach to analyzing professional and vernacular estrangement discourse because "in qualitative practice like this, the data and sample come first" (Tracy, 2012, p. 117).

Further, we believe that many critical theories can be productively applied by scholars of family communication. Power, after all, operates in multiple, complex ways (Foucault, 1983). Hence, a multiplicity of critical theories, perspectives, and vocabularies are essential to the study of power and family communication. Specifically, we embrace Baxter and Asbury's (2014) call for scholars of interpersonal and family communication to adopt critical postmodern theoretical orientations. In contrast to critical modern scholars who focus on the oppressive power of ideological/structural systems, critical postmodern scholars "adopt a more locally emergent and contingent view of power in which discourses—language-based systems of knowledge claims about what is and what ought to be—supplant individual consciousness as the focus of scholarly attention" (p. 191). In this sense, power does not simply refer to the actions of the wealthy or powerful, and power is not only something that individuals or institutions *have* or *exert*. Instead, Foucault (1983) wrote,

This form of power applies itself to immediate everyday life which categorizes the individual, marks him by his own individuality, attaches him to his own identity, imposes a law of truth on him which he must recognize and which others have to recognize in him. It is a form of power which makes individuals subjects. (p. 212)

The discursive process of naming, defining, and becoming subjects rejects the idea of the inherent, preexisting self. Thus, discourse from a postmodern/poststructural perspective is conceptualized as the articulation of knowledge and power, which operates through naturalizing knowledges (Foucault, 1978). We thus interrogated "the dominant discourses that we often take for granted as the appropriate and necessary functional and affective elements of family" (Baxter, 2014, p. 44). However, it is important to note that "postmodernism" encompasses a diverse range of theories and perspectives (Mumby, 1997), and critical family communication scholars should be explicit about whose theories, concepts, and ideas they draw upon. Next we describe our analysis of estrangement discourse in professional and interpersonal communication utilizing a critical-qualitative approach framed by Butler's theory of performativity.

METHOD: CRITICAL-QUALITATIVE ANALYSES OF ESTRANGEMENT DISCOURSE

To provide transparency in our methods (Tracy, 2012), we first explain the interview procedures, then specify our analytical procedures for examining both professional and vernacular discourse, and finally describe our theoretical lens.

Participants

In 2014, the first author interviewed 16 individuals with at least one self-identified estranged family member, including immediate and extended, about their stories of estrangement. The first author deviated from recruiting practices used by previous estrangement scholars in this process by not providing a definition of estrangement and asking participants to self-identify. Put simply, when scholars calling for estranged participants include established definitions, such as “family conflict, poor communication,” and in opposition to “family connectedness and attachment” (Winters, Stinchfield, Lee, & Latimer, 2008, pp. 3–4), they are excluding those participants who self-identify as estranged without the negative connotations, thereby limiting the understanding of estrangement as a complex experience. Because the first author desired to be as open as possible about the lived experiences of estrangement, she sought participants who “identified as estranged and willing to share the story of [their] estrangement.”

The first author recruited participants from introductory communication courses at a midwestern university. She also reached out to personal and professional networks using a purposeful sampling method, wherein she recruited participants and generated interview data to “fit the parameters of the project’s research questions, goals, and purposes” (Tracy, 2013, p. 134). In accordance with the Internal Review Board, all participants were above the age of 19 and consented to be interviewed and audio-recorded for the purpose of this study. Ultimately, 11 women and 5 men completed face-to-face or phone interviews, and the age of participants averaged 26 years old. Fourteen participants identified as Caucasian, one participant identified as American Indian, and one participant identified as Asian. Participants discussed a variety of estranged family relationships, including estrangement from their parents, children, siblings, and cousins.

To investigate the participants’ experiences of estrangement, the first author developed a semistructured interview guide (Kvale, 1996) that employed a guiding framework for questions but allowed participants the freedom to tell their stories of family estrangement. The first author pretested the interview guide on two volunteers and made some minor syntactic adjustments prior to the investigation. The interview protocol was designed to delve into participants’ experiences of family estrangement through two main foci. First, the first author prompted participants to tell their stories of estrangement by asking, “I would like to know your story of estrangement. In as much detail as you feel comfortable please tell me the story of your estrangement.” Depending on the richness of their descriptions, participants were then asked to clarify the actor, precipitating events, and emotions accompanying their experience. Second, the first author asked participants to reflect on the relational ideals, satisfaction, and desired future with their estranged family member.

Analysis

Through initial reading and rereading of the transcripts, we quickly realized that some participants’ stories challenged the dominant discursive construction of family

estrangement presented by professionals and scholars, which we had previously informally observed as positioning family estrangement as a problem that needed to be solved. Nearly half of the participants strongly resisted the notion that their estranged family relationship was dysfunctional in their stories of estrangement. To analyze these participants' novel articulation of family estrangement, we engaged in an iterative process of critical-qualitative analysis where we vacillated between reading the transcripts, reading the professional and scholarly literature, and reading theory that might frame our analysis (Tracy, 2012). This process was guided by Owen's (1984) principles of *repetition*, *recurrence*, and *forcefulness*, where we inductively coded and categorized emergent themes across the literature and interviews. We adopted Tracy's (2013) assertion that "analysis is a creative and messy process—one in which researchers attempt to harness their instincts and hunches, so that they may come to significant, or even groundbreaking insights about the data" (p. 224).

To systematically and critically analyze the meanings of estrangement in professional discourse, we performed a literature search that progressed in two phases. First, we consulted family counseling and psychology literature that dealt explicitly with estrangement. We chose to focus on this literature because it informs both scholarly and professional understandings of estrangement. Second, based on this initial finding, we broadened our search to include extant literature about emotional cutoff and corresponding constructs of family health and functioning found in the family strength literature. As we coded themes in the professional literature, we took note of the way in which family "health," "strength," and "functioning" were constructed in a similar way to perpetuate a "grand narrative" (Alvesson & Sköldberg, 2009, p. 191) or "universal truth" (Cannella, 2015, p. 10) of what families should strive toward. Through this analytical process, we ultimately noted two overarching categories of the *functional family* and *dysfunctional family*, themes which emerged across professional and scholarly discourse about estrangement. We noted that the meanings of family function and dysfunction were generally oppositional, which led us to consider how poststructural theory might guide an analysis of how "discourse and language give expression to particular power relations, and lock people into various forms of subjectivity" or identity (Alvesson & Sköldberg, 2009, p. 195).

Concurrently, while critiquing the professional literature about estrangement, we noted how some of the first author's interview participants seemed to resist or problematize the functional family/dysfunctional family binary, in turn solidifying our poststructural theoretical orientation because "the paradigm not only highlights occasions of domination and self-subordination, but also accentuates avenues for resistance and change" (Tracy, 2013, p. 44). To closely analyze this emergent moment of resistance, we identified which participants aligned with, and diverged from, articulating their estrangement as dysfunctional. We then read and reread the transcripts of those participants who articulated their feelings about their estranged family as contrary to dysfunction. Subsequently, we coded and categorized the nuanced ways in which some participants redefined the meaning of the *functional family* in ways that were contrary to the professional literature, paying particular attention to how participants framed their estranged family relationships as "positive," "happy," or even

“ambivalent.” During this iterative process of engaging with the literature and the interview data, we selected Butler’s (1990, 1993) poststructural theory of performativity to frame our analysis.

Performativity

Philosopher Judith Butler (1990, 1993) developed the theory of performativity to account for the power of discourse to name and make intelligible gender and sexual identity categories. Drawing on poststructural philosophers Jacques Derrida and Michel Foucault, Butler asserted that gender categories are constructed, and individual identity does not precede discourse, but rather becomes sedimented and taken as natural over time through the process Butler termed performativity. Specifically, the repetition or citation of discourses over time materializes identity binaries, or dueling oppositions, that function to make identities intelligible in our culture (e.g., male/female). The power of discourse, then, is to produce what it names by naturalizing and normalizing identity categories while simultaneously disciplining those who do not conform (Butler, 1993). For example, Sloop (2004) illustrated how transgender identities are continuously disciplined into strict female/male and gay/straight binaries in news media. Butler and other scholars of performativity (e.g., Chávez, 2010; Sloop, 2004); call for the deconstruction of binary categories such as man/woman, often by critiquing the repetition of discourses in media. However, this performative citation of norms does not only take place on a cultural level, it also takes place on the vernacular level among “communities that have been systematically ignored” (Ono & Sloop, 1995, p. 20). While estranged family relationships have not traditionally been considered marginalized, we contend that functional family estrangement has been ignored, and thus warrants study.

Although Butler and others have focused primarily on gender performativity, or the ongoing reproduction of gendered norms, we argue that the theory of performativity may be applied to the construction of any identity category (Jackson, 2004), including family identity. Further, Butler’s (1990, 1993) theory of performativity also leaves room for subversion, or acts that make visible and “trouble” the construction of naturalized identity categories. Drag performers, for example, sometimes subvert gender binaries by making apparent the constructedness of doing gender through parody (Butler, 1993). Although subversion has been less theorized than performativity, Brickell (2005) argued that subversion may be expanded beyond some forms of parody (e.g., drag) to include “those symbolisms and performances that present resources and materials for reconfiguring subjectivities and, hence, action and interaction” (p. 37). Performativity, then, accounts for how (family) identities come to be intelligible, continue to be maintained, and are sometimes troubled. Importantly, the political goal of the scholar of performativity is not to elevate the marginalized side of the binary to equal status of the privileged identity, but rather to deconstruct the binary altogether “to make life more livable for those rendered unintelligible” (Chávez, 2010, p. 1). For example, gender performativity scholars critique naturalized gender

categories in order to advocate for transgender or intersex people who remain invalid within the male/female binary. Given the critical potential of performativity to make sense of power and discourse, we argue that performativity is useful for deconstructing the disconnect between professional and everyday discourse about family identity, specifically estrangement and family (dys)function. Thus, two research questions oriented our analysis: (a) how does professional discourse construct family estrangement; and (b) how do individuals who self-identify as estranged trouble this construction?

RESULTS: CONSTRUCTING AND TROUBLING THE FUNCTIONAL/DYSFUNCTIONAL FAMILY BINARY

Based on Butler's conceptualization of power and performativity, we critique the performative construction of the functional family/dysfunctional family binary in professional and scholarly literature, and then analyze how some participants' stories subvert this binary by articulating their families as *functionally estranged*.

Constructing the Binary

Deconstructing the functional/dysfunctional family binary in professional discourse illustrates how the binary is performatively maintained and naturalized. Specifically, this binary equates functional family identity with open, ongoing, and positive communication between family members, while dysfunctional family identity is equated with minimal communication, including estrangement and relational distance or cutoff. Through the repetition of this discourse in professional literature, the family with ongoing open communication is essentialized as natural, thereby constructing a bio-legal understanding of what family is and should be. Thus, power operates in professional discourse by performatively constituting knowledges about what functional family ought to be: not estranged.

The functional/dysfunctional family binary is foregrounded in the theorization of the family as a system. Family systems theory is predicated on the assumption that all families are interdependent, and functional families are cohesive and balanced, achieving homeostasis (Olson & DeFrain, 2006). Olson and DeFrain articulated these when they wrote that families "are like a mobile: each member fits into the whole in a unique way and adds to the beauty of the whole. If one individual changes—for better or worse—the total creation is affected" (p. 3). Fundamentally an ecological theory, family systems theory naturalizes the well-functioning family as cross-culturally occurring and enduring (DeFrain & Asay, 2007), creating an imperative for families to strive for a telos of cohesion between family members, lest they risk damaging the delicate balance of the family system. According to systems theory, the dysfunctional family is constructed as out of balance and in need of professional intervention.

As the functioning family system is naturalized, so are its relational patterns of open and clear communication, open emotional expression, and shared time together.

While different programs of research name the qualities of a functional family differently, family connection, communication, problem-solving, and shared time cross cut all investigations of “strong” families. Beavers and Hampson (1990) argued that the functional family is best characterized by openness, empathy, and closeness. Billingsley’s (1986) findings suggested that strong family ties are key to functional and balanced family systems. Further operationalizing what enhances a family’s functionality, Greef (2000) explained that family pride, accord, and communication are resources functional families have available. Building on these definitions, DeFrain (2007) argued for a strength-based approach to family therapy delineating functioning families across six dimensions: appreciation, affection, positive communication, spiritual well-being, commitment, enjoyable time together, and the ability to manage stress and crisis. The functional family, then, is performatively reiterated in professional literature as one that has achieved systemic balance through positive and ongoing communication behaviors.

These assumptions are carried over to therapeutic family assessment. The McMaster approach, also situated in the family systems paradigm, measures dimensions of family functioning across problem solving, communication, affective responsiveness, and affective involvement (Miller, Ryan, Keitner, & Epstein, 2000). This scale is also used in its short form to more quickly assess family function and dysfunction with items like “We can express feelings to each other” and “We cannot talk to each other about the sadness we feel” (Botherhoven de Haan, Hafekost, Lawrence, Sawyer, & Zubrick, 2015, p. 117.) The role of family therapists and other professionals then becomes a matter of facilitating these behaviors to achieve the apex of family system functioning. Explicit across the professional literature in this is the idea that the family is a naturally occurring, indivisible unit that requires professional assistance when family balance is upset due to improper communication between family members.

It is not surprising that family estrangement is constructed by professional discourse as a dysfunctional family pattern, because the family is understood through knowledges of the family as a naturally occurring, interdependent unit. As a response to the relative lack of research on the subject, estrangement has drawn attention from scholars in a variety of fields including social work, psychology, sociology, counseling psychology, and communication (Agllias, 2011a; Carr et al., 2015; Robinson et al., 2001; Sichel, 2004; Sucov, 2006). Across these diverse approaches studies of estrangement typically maintain three stable features: lack of communication, conflict and negative emotion, and the need for professional intervention. These features, we argue, constitute the performative construction of estranged family identity.

First, undergirding this characterization of estrangement as unhealthy and undesirable is an emphasis on the absence of communication and inadequate communication as primary causes for estrangement. Davis (2013) argued, “Estrangements most often start because we lack the communication skills to prevent them; we do not know how to apologize, listen, or cool off and talk again tomorrow” (p. 34). The natural role of communication then is to maintain intimacy between family members, and it is only when that role is disrupted that nonintimacy in the form of estrangement characterizes the family unit. Kelly (2003) further illustrates this point by stating, “Estrangement is

often considered a process maintained by feelings of hurt and inadequate communication skills” (p. 25). This aligns good communication with functional families, while simultaneously aligning poor communication with dysfunctional, estranged families. This distinction remains prevalent in proposed interventions for estranged families (DeFrain, Cook, & Gonzalez-Kruger, 2005).

Second, in addition to conceptualizing estrangement as a disruption of healthy family functioning, research also characterizes it as the result of major conflict and negative emotion. Agllias (2013) articulated this component of estrangement when she wrote, “The estrangement was highly stressful and traumatic, and the lack of clarity surrounding it appeared to threaten their well-being and resilience” (p. 309). Estrangement is also depicted as the result of “non-normative” stressors or circumstances (Kelly, 2003, p. 95). On an individual level estrangement is often characterized as a reaction to severe family dysfunction like abuse (Agllias, 2015; Scharp, Thomas, & Paxman, 2015). Scholars write that many individuals engage in “emotional cut off” when the family system becomes stressed or imbalanced (Bowen, 1986); however, while the emotional cutoff may initially relieve an individual, according to systems theory, it is detrimental for the family as a whole (Miller et al., 2000). Estrangement in these characterizations is simultaneously a reaction to dysfunction on an individual level and the center of dysfunction on the family level. In other words, while estrangement may initially prove beneficial for the individual, it is a sign of the family system’s dysfunction (Bowen, 1986; Miller et al., 2000). Conflict and negative emotion, then, are enacted as characteristics of the dysfunctional, estranged family that require professional intervention.

Third, the idea that professional intervention is necessary pervades scholarship about estrangement. As a result of the systems assumptions, interventions are family-wide necessities that disrupt unhealthy interaction patterns, thereby improving communication and intimacy (Kelly, 2003). While empirical research focusing on estrangement is sparse, psychological musings on how to rectify the loss of intimacy in family relationships is more abundant with authors providing recommendations to enhance coping (LeBey, 2001; Sichel, 2004), improve communication (Davis, 2013; Sucov, 2006), and resolve conflict (Liberman, 2002). Friedlander and Walters (2010) ultimately rearticulated the importance of family interventions when they said, “A child’s resistance or refusal to spend time with a parent often becomes more entrenched over time, highlighting the importance of early intervention” (p. 108). Following this logic, Dattilio and Nichols (2011) advocated for a cognitive-behavioral approach to reconciling estranged families by addressing family “dysfunctional schemas” that cause conflict and thus relational distance (p. 90). The researchers elaborated on these methods of intervention, arguing that cognitive-behavioral techniques “allow us to provide family members with skills to mediate emotionally charged responses and facilitate more effective communication and behavioral exchange” (p. 97).

Even studies that characterize estrangement as a reaction to severe family dysfunction suggest their findings could be used to inform family-level interventions. Agllias’s (2016) study of adult children who chose to become estranged from their parents

argued that a primary purpose of completing this research was to inform clinical and counseling interventions. When dealing specifically with estrangement as a reaction to trauma Agllias (2016) suggested,

Long-term therapeutic goals that encourage an empathic examination of the other side of the story (including intergenerational culture, patterns, and myths), a realistic evaluation of change capacity, and an acknowledgment of past wrongdoings (where applicable), have great potential to increase personal growth and contribute to more informed decisions about the estrangement status. Indeed, family therapists have long suggested that dealing with issues in the family of origin will also have beneficial effects on current relationships. (p. 11)

This framing of estrangement is critical to the discursive construction of the functional/dysfunctional family binary, which rigidly constrains the meaning of family functionality. According to this perspective, while estrangement can be experienced positively on an individual level, it requires intervention on the family level not only for the benefit of the family of origin but for the health of future relationships and family systems as well. Two implications of this construction emerge. First, these discourses imply that therapeutic intervention has the potential to help the family system regain functionality by addressing histories of abuse and maltreatment. Second, discourses imply whole functioning family systems are most beneficial to individuals, thus privileging the health of the family system.

Within the functional/dysfunctional family binary family estrangement becomes part of the performative materialization of the family dysfunction. Power thus operates through the strict discursive naturalizing of the “functional family” and the simultaneous pathologizing of the estranged “dysfunctional family,” where the functional family is continually privileged over the dysfunctional family in professional discourse. This normalizes the idea that family members must have open, ongoing communication to sustain family equilibrium, health, and well-being. This is problematic because binaries operate reductively to constrain our understanding of what a family is and should be, thereby privileging a bio-legal definition of family as nonvoluntary and constructing estrangement as anything but dysfunctional to be unintelligible. Although professionals are likely aware that estrangement is not necessarily *always* dysfunctional, the performative discourses of estrangement in professional literature constitute a narrow reality of estrangement that undoubtedly contributes to the cultural understanding of estrangement as inherently abnormal and therefore undesirable. However, some individuals who self-identify as estranged from a family member trouble this classification, and redefine the functional family as necessarily including estrangement.

Troubling the Binary

In the present case, participants’ discourse sometimes troubled or subverted the functional/dysfunctional family binary by articulating their estranged family identity outside of these two established categories. Subversion is defined as identity performances that make visible the constructedness of identity categories and/or reconfigure

established subjectivities (Brickell, 2005; Butler, 1990, 1993). Thus, participants who troubled the functional/dysfunctional family binary denaturalized equating estrangement with family dysfunction that is sedimented or solidified in professional discourse. In turn, participants nudge frames of intelligibility and shift the powerful construction of family functionality to be less constraining and more inclusive (Brickell, 2005). It is important to note that many participants reified the discourse cited by professionals by framing their estrangement as dysfunctional. This is not surprising given that vernacular discourse is often culturally affirming rather than culturally resistant (Ono & Sloop, 1995). Our focus here, however, is to highlight some participants' subversion that gives voice to *one* nondominant discourse presently ignored by family practitioners and scholars. Thus, the present analysis is not meant to be reductive, decisive, or totalizing, but rather to open up one possibility for the transformation (Cannella, 2015) of how we view what family is and should be. Following the critical-qualitative analytic framework outlined in our method section, participants consistently articulated a family identity that was *functionally estranged*, thereby subverting the performative binary that dictates what communicative practices comprise a functional family. Participants articulated a functionally estranged family identity by describing their estranged family relationships as (a) ongoing and ideal, and/or (b) ambivalent, but (c) often unintelligible to others.

First, participants resisted the functional/dysfunctional family binary by making a distinction between estranged and terminated relationships. As previously stated, many scholars have conceptualized estrangement as the cessation of a familial relationship (e.g., Carr et al., 2015). Articulating a contradictory experience in her story of estrangement from her adult brother, Carol said:

Like if I didn't consider him a family member I would say I have one brother. That to me would be a terminated relationship. One brother and that is it, but really I have two. I still believe I have two. I don't choose to interact with one of them, but he is still my brother, that is still a relationship that exists between us. Even if we do not in fact relate with one another very often.

Here, Carol articulates an experience of estrangement that differs from relational termination. We maintain that these estranged relationships, like all relationships, are constituted in routine, meaningful silence. In the case of estrangement, routine silence constitutes a relationship that is distant where there was once closeness. This problematizes the functional/dysfunctional family binary by suggesting that estranged relationships are not ruptured, fractured, or terminated relationships; rather, they are communicatively negotiated and ongoing. While she clearly identifies as estranged because of a lack of interaction, she still identifies her brother as a member of her family. Carol's experience further troubles the functional/dysfunctional family binary by asserting that the distant relationship she maintains with her brother is preferable to that of a close relationship:

You know, I kind of feel like this is ideal for me because I do not feel like I can have my—like I wouldn't voluntarily have my kids around his views. I like them around diversity, but I don't like them around things that I think are actually hateful or

harmful, so I don't think I probably want a close relationship. Like I wouldn't want him to come stay in my home. I would not want to go stay in his home. ... Just because they are family doesn't mean you should have relationships with them.

Carol's experience of the ideal familial relationship with her brother deviates from the prescriptive of close intimate relationship articulated in the functional/dysfunctional binary. Further, it challenges this binary by expressing the functionality of the relationship. Carol was not alone in her preference for distant familial relationships. Natasha indicated a similar experience in her story of estrangement from her father when asked if she would be interested in mending the relationship with him:

I don't think it is like really broken, so I guess if the question is, "Would I be interested in having more frequent contact with him?" Probably not. I think we are at a good homeostasis ... now; it is just like a silent agreement that we don't talk to each other, but it is kind of a positive thing.

Natasha's experience challenges the functional/dysfunctional family binary by articulating an experience of estrangement that is positive, preferable, and stable instead of negative and out of equilibrium. Standing in stark contrast with the notion that estranged families are rife with conflict, negative emotion, and ruptured, Natasha expresses a positive distant relationship with the man she still identifies as her father and a member of her family. Her experience further challenges the binary by not having the desire to have a closer relationship and denying the necessity of intervention, a key tenet of the dysfunctional family discourse surrounding estrangement.

Second, while some participants indicated that their estranged family relationships were ideal, other participants expressed ambivalence about their ongoing estrangement. Not always divorced from strong emotions, some participants expressed ambivalence toward changing it, thereby troubling the professional labeling of dysfunction and prescription of family therapy for estrangement. In the estrangement from her son, Christina expressed this perspective when she stated:

Based on the fact that they have not made overtures at all. I just—I can only conclude that they are happy with the way things are. They are living their lives. They are content. They don't see any need for me to be a part of it. They have moved on with their lives, so have I? I don't dwell on his. It is a painful thing, but it wouldn't do me any good at all to be rude and be upset all the time. When I do have conversations, yeah there is a deep pain in my heart, and I will be sad for a few minutes. But, I have so many other good things in my life to be thankful and joyful for. I just choose not to allow that to rule me or manage me or influence me on a daily basis.

By expressing a desire to move on with her life, Christina challenges the functional/dysfunctional family binary that asserts that family members should be in constant, positive contact to be functional. Far from experiencing the constant torture of a ruptured family system, Christina's experience speaks to the everyday ambivalence that comes from a stable family system with sedimented patterns of interaction, or lack thereof.

In this critique of vernacular discourse, we focused on participant's stories of estrangement that subverted the functional/dysfunctional binary; however, it is

important to note that not all participants troubled this binary. Some participants reiterated estrangement as dysfunctional, while other participants articulated experiences that simultaneously subverted and reified the functional/dysfunctional family binary. Hilda, for example, articulated this complexity in her estrangement from her sister:

If she were different, then I mean what would be ideal would be to see her all the time. Living in the same city and hang out with each other and have mutual friends, mutual interests, hobbies that we shared. That would be if she was different, so I mean really this is almost the ideal situation because the reality is that she isn't different.

In her interview, Hilda reiterated the functional/dysfunctional binary by aligning the ideal family as intimate and positive. Ultimately, by realizing that the relationship with her sister does not fit this ideal, Hilda decentered the intimate family ideal in favor of her own estranged relational ideal.

Third, participants' stories indicated that this subversive family identity of functional estrangement is not always easily intelligible to others, thus reinforcing the power of the functional/dysfunctional family binary in our culture. In her discussion of estrangement from her father, Mandy typified the power of professional discourses that render family estrangement intelligible only through its equation with family functionality:

Most people have slightly more to their families. And I just don't. I don't find it particularly troubling or worrying, and I am ok with me and my family. You don't find people with that kind of calm. People put a lot of effort into their extended families, and I don't understand it. I have better things to do. It has never been rewarding. I have better uses of my time than maintaining relationships for the sake of genetics. ... I find more meaning in the relationships that I create and not where they are there just because I was born. Most people think of estrangement as this huge traumatic thing, and most people I run into are people of a huge family drama. I don't feel more screwed up than people in normal families. Maybe I am, and I don't know it. Maybe this is a huge red flag. Plus you hear things like, "Children with strong families go on to do this that and the other." And I am like, "Well, I am moderately successful in my life I believe. What about me?"

Fundamentally, Mandy articulates a family identity that is both estranged and functional, though her conviction about her family's functionality is tentative. She subverts the functional/dysfunctional family binary by pointing out that her experience of positive family estrangement is not represented in the binary constituted in professional discourse. Mandy continually contrasts her experiences and beliefs about family with the ideal represented in professional discourse, and directly addresses professional discourses by challenging the success of children from "strong" families with her own experience and identity as a successful individual from an estranged family. In doing so, she denaturalizes the functional/dysfunctional family binary and emphasizes the constructedness of family functioning.

Together these participants' stories challenge current professional discourse about estrangement. Instead of adhering to a strict binary of estrangement as dysfunctional

and intimacy as functional, participants often articulated estranged relationships that were at times distant, ambivalent, *and* functional. It is important to note that subversion is never separate from performativity, and the possibilities for subversion are never outside of existing identity binaries (Butler, 1990, 1993). Subversive identity performances, then, can never fully reject or eschew the identity binary sedimented through the repeated citation of discourse. Rather, troubling of the functional/dysfunctional family binary works by denaturalizing and rendering visible the constructedness of taken-for-granted knowledges about what an estranged family is and should be. As we have illustrated, individuals who self-identify as estranged from a family member denaturalize different aspects of the knowledges imbued in professional discourses of family estrangement.

CONCLUSION: IMPLICATIONS OF (DYS)FUNCTIONAL ESTRANGEMENT

These findings have important implications for how “strong” and successful families are constructed by professions, and in turn affect families. Scholars and practitioners have a responsibility to be conscious about how the “functional family” is named and articulated, paying special attention to the types of families that may be excluded, or even unnecessarily pathologized, in the discourse of family professionals. In the case of estrangement, nearly half of the interviewed individuals who self-identified as estranged from a family member destabilized the professional naturalization of dysfunctional estrangement, and created a new subjectivity of the *functionally estranged family*. The identification of this subversive family identity was possible because the first author asked her interview participants to self-identify as estranged, thereby creating a space for the stories of those who view their estrangement less negatively than scholarly and professional definitions often mandate. By drawing attention to participants’ subversion, we hope to disrupt the prescriptive roles of intimacy and closeness in discourses that constitute families in an effort to prevent the “singling out of one form of relation ... over all others” (Halberstam, 2012, p. 111).

It is not completely surprising that professionals who deal with estrangement on a clinical level primarily come across patients who are dissatisfied with their estranged relationships. However, we argue that professional discourse problematically perpetuates the functional/dysfunctional family binary at the expense of other articulations of family estrangement. Professional discourse is encountered by individuals from all backgrounds, and constitutes a privileged body of knowledge within and outside of the academy. Even though family professionals may be aware that estrangement isn’t *always* dysfunctional, the functional/dysfunctional family binary continues to be sedimented in professional discourse, thereby maintaining an operation of power that defines what families are and ought to be (Baxter & Asbury, 2014). Professional discourse naturalizes the family as a unified, naturally occurring, bio-legal system, which performatively constructs and maintains a taken-for-granted knowledge that estrangement is inherently dysfunctional. However, some individuals who self-identify as estranged denaturalize the performative estranged family identity,

thereby subverting this problematic binary and rupturing professional interpretations of family functionality. We term this subversive articulation of estrangement, overlooked in previous research due to narrow operational definitions, *functional family estrangement*. This articulation opens up more possibilities for what counts as a functional, good, or “strong” family. As such, our critical analysis points to applied implications about how we name and define estrangement and family functionality.

Specifically, the present analysis offers two, practical insights into family estrangement. First, professionals and scholars should not assume that estrangement is always dysfunctional in their popular and scholarly writings, and should instead recognize the family as constructed rather than natural. By breaking down this binary, we will gain a more nuanced understanding of the complex and sometimes contradictory lived experiences of estrangement. Second, professionals and scholars should carefully examine how their discourses play a role in the powerful articulation of binaries that structure our understandings of ourselves, our relationships, and our realities. Because the history of norms “constitute[s] the power of discourse to enact what it means” (Butler, 1993, p. 187), imagine how individuals might reconceptualize their estranged family relationships outside the need for medical/psychiatric intervention if estrangement is not pathologized and repeatedly constructed as problematic by family professionals. Our point is not to argue that estranged relationships never benefit from professional help; on the contrary, traumatic experiences of estrangement are very real and may benefit from reconciliation. However, as long as the functional/dysfunctional family binary continues to be maintained by scholars and professionals, functionally estranged families will continue to be constructed as illegitimate, invalid, and unintelligible.

In addition to problematizing the functional/dysfunctional family binary, we have demonstrated the value in utilizing critical family communication scholarship. Critical scholarship, after all, struggles to gain legitimacy among interpersonal and family communication scholars (Baxter & Braithwaite, 2006; Braithwaite et al., 2014, 2014). We offer three implications for future critical family communication scholarship. First, there is a need to critically, empirically analyze everyday experiences in order to identify, critique, and transform more covert operations of power. Although we argue that professionals simplify and naturalize the meaning of family in an operation of power through knowledge construction, the functional/dysfunctional family binary cuts across traditional intersectional categories of gender, race, class, sexuality, age, and so forth (Ipsos MORI, 2014). Poststructural orientations toward power, including Butler’s (1990, 1993) theory of performativity, we argue, can attune critical family communication scholars to the mundane operations of power that perpetuate knowledges about what families should be (Baxter, 2014). Performativity is a theory especially sensitized to the everyday repetition or citation of discourses that construct individual and family identity binaries. Identifying and deconstructing these binaries should be a future task of critical family communication scholars who seek to render intelligible the experiences of those who do not fit into performative identity categories. As we have illustrated here, studying vernacular discourse offers one avenue for rendering intelligible those who do not conform to (family) identity binaries.

Second, there is a need to sometimes modify and/or eschew a deductive, social scientific writing style in critical family communication scholarship. Critical scholarship is neither neutral nor objective, and should neither strive to be nor apologize for the fact that it is not. Tracy (2012) wrote that published qualitative scholars often “use existing theory and empirical evidence to provide a priori rationales that justify the assumptions guiding the research questions and data analysis” (p. 112) and, in turn, center rationality, linearity, and deductive logic. The point of critical analysis is *not* to write in a way that is neutral and replicable, but rather to write in a way that articulates something novel and important about the operations of power, and offers transformative possibilities (Cannella, 2015; Tracy, 2012, 2013). As such, we have de-emphasized a social scientific writing style by forgoing an a priori review of the literature. Instead, we noted a moment of power wherein professionals problematically define what counts as a functional family that is challenged by the voices of some estranged individuals, and worked from there to identify and critique the functional/dysfunctional family binary. By analyzing professional and scholarly literature, rather than framing it within a literature review to justify the present study, we were able to unearth an articulation of power in which estranged families are always already constructed as dysfunctional, regardless of alternative lived experiences.

Third, there is a need to integrate and develop a multitude of critical theories within family communication scholarship. By employing Butler’s theory of performativity, we offer one new orientation to the critical perspectives already present in family communication scholarship, thereby answering Baxter and Asbury’s (2014) call for critical postmodern perspectives in interpersonal and family communication research, and Manning’s (2014) call “to begin borrowing theories from one tradition and seeing how they hold up in another” (p. 438). Through exploring and integrating a breadth of perspectives from critical/cultural studies, family communication scholarship will not only be theoretically and analytically enriched, but will be in conversation with critical scholars of rhetoric, media studies, and organizational communication. This will help achieve productive dialectical-dialogical tension between the traditions in our field (Craig, 1999; Manning, 2014), and will help us understand, and work against, unjust operations of power in family contexts.

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